



THE LONELINESS EPIDEMIC

Its Impact on Youth & How We Can Help

Mary Rogers Kirby, LPC



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and resource toolkit

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Agenda

Impact of loneliness on mental and physical health.

Mental health and social media use trends.

Actions you can take to combat loneliness in youth.

Our Epidemic of Loneliness and Isolation:

The U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory on the Healing Effects of Social Connection and Community

Vivek Murthy, M.D., M.B.A
19th and 21st Surgeon General
of the United States



Let's Hear from Dr.
Murthy About the Advisory





Loneliness vs. Social Isolation

Loneliness is a subjective emotional state – a feeling of being alone or disconnected, even when surrounded by people. It stems from unmet social or emotional needs.

Social isolation is an objective lack of social contact – minimal interaction with others, regardless of whether it causes distress. Someone can be socially isolated but not feel lonely, and vice versa.

What is Social Connection?

The Three Vital Components of Social Connection

The extent to which an individual is socially connected depends on multiple factors, including:

Structure

The number and variety of relationships and frequency of interactions

Function

The degree to which relationships serve various needs

Quality

The positive and negative aspects of relationships and interactions

Household Size
Friend circle size
Marital/partnership status

Emotional support
Mentorship
Support in a crisis

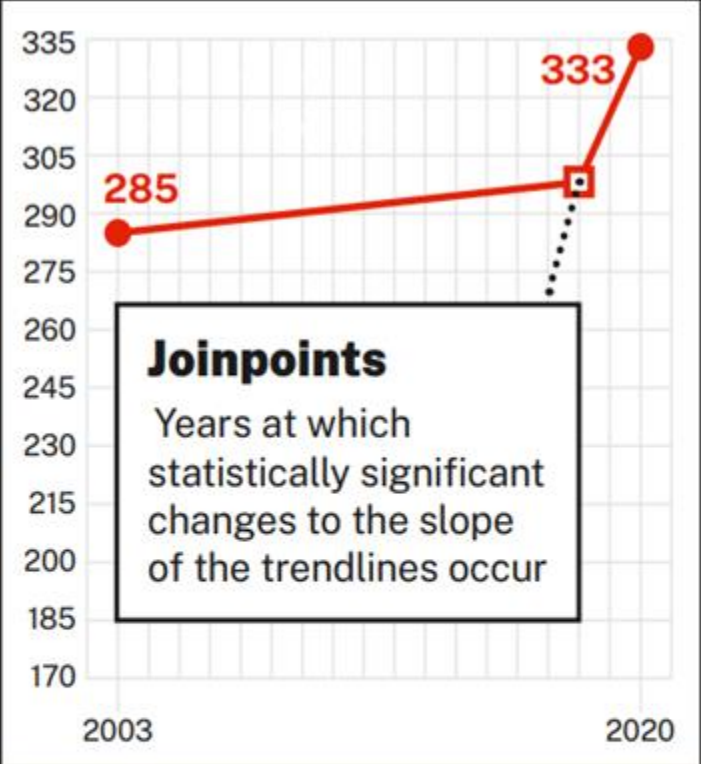
Relationship satisfaction
Relationship strain
Social inclusion or exclusion

National Trends for Social Connection

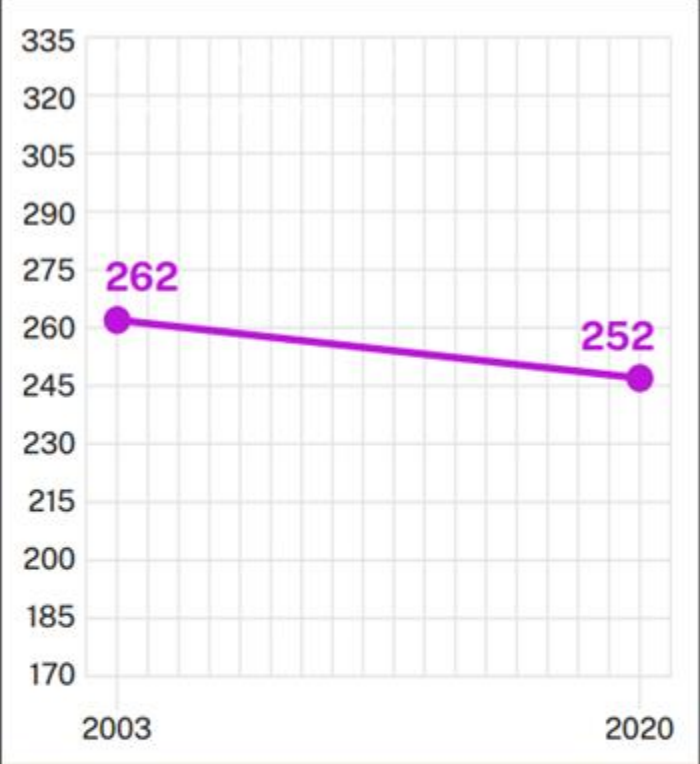
From 2003 to 2020, time spent alone increased, while time spent on in-person social engagement decreased.



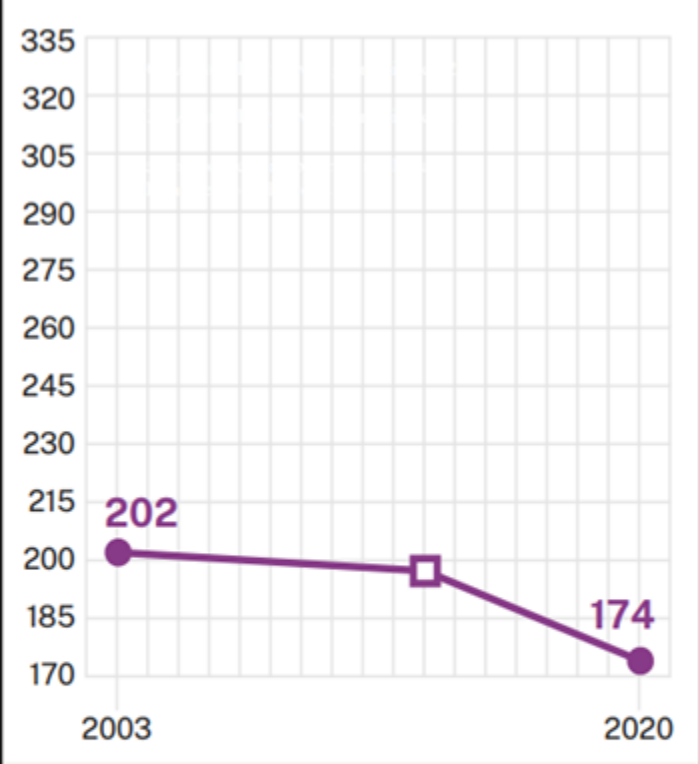
ANNUAL DAILY AVERAGE IN MINUTES



Social Isolation
an increase of **24 hours** per month



Household Family Social Engagement
a decrease of **5 hours** per month



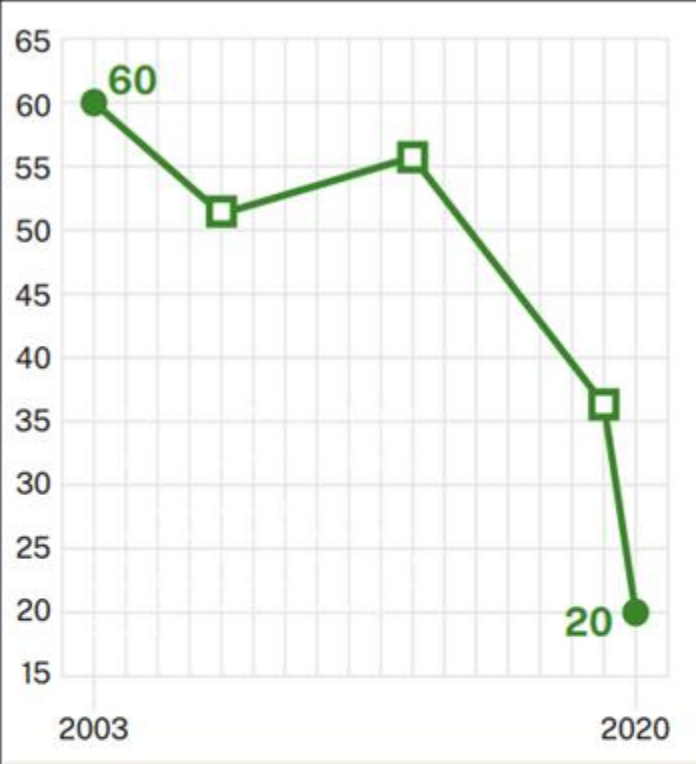
Companionship
a decrease of **14 hours** per month
Companionship refers to shared leisure for the sake of enjoyment and intrinsic satisfaction

National Trends for Social Connection

From 2003 to 2020, time spent alone increased, while time spent on in-person social engagement decreased.



ANNUAL DAILY AVERAGE IN MINUTES



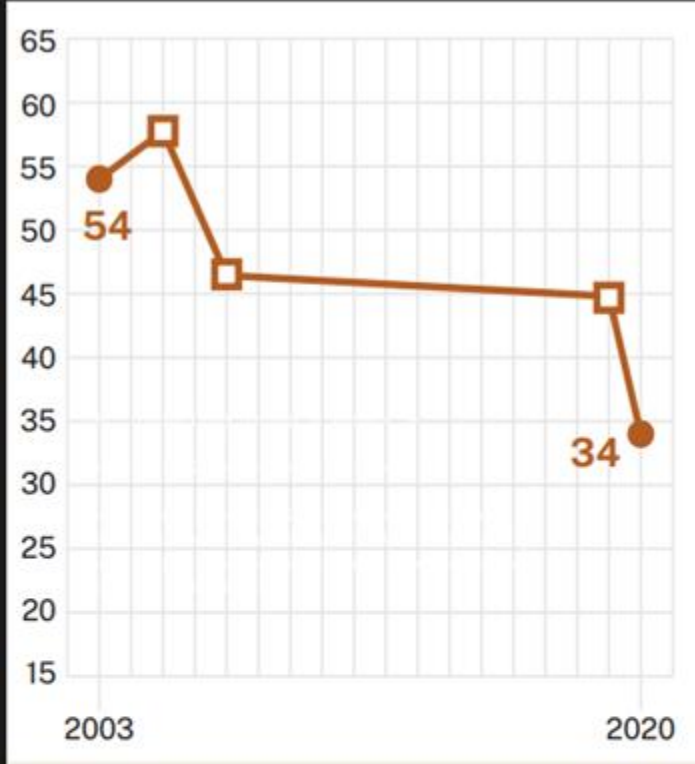
Social Engagement with Friends

a decrease of **20 hours** per month



Non-Household Family Social Engagement

a decrease of **6.5 hours** per month

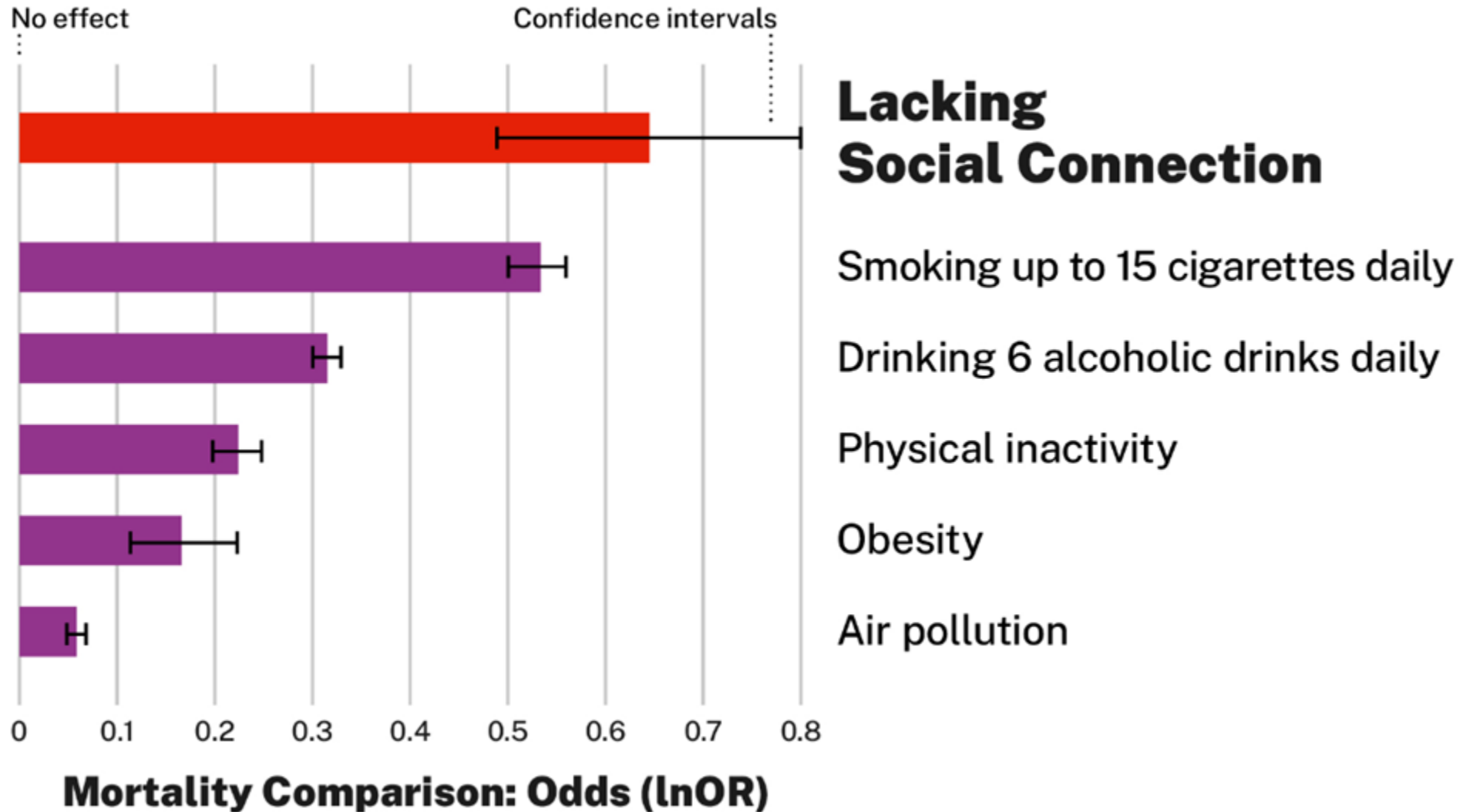


Social Engagement with Others

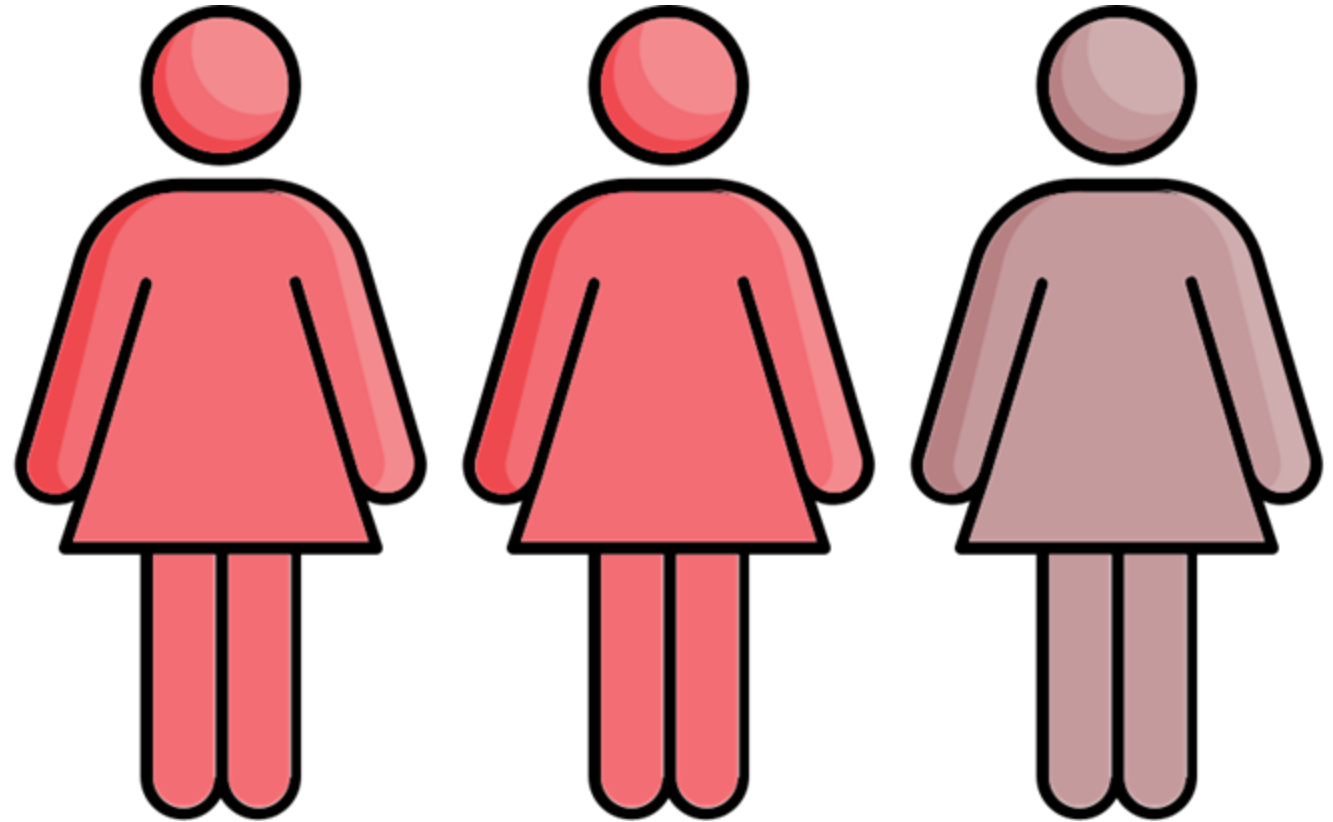
a decrease of **10 hours** per month

Impacts on Health

Lack of social connection is an independent risk factor for death



**11-17
year-olds
stressed
by
loneliness**



Feeling Lonely?



42%
Alpha



43%
Gen Z



32%
Millennials

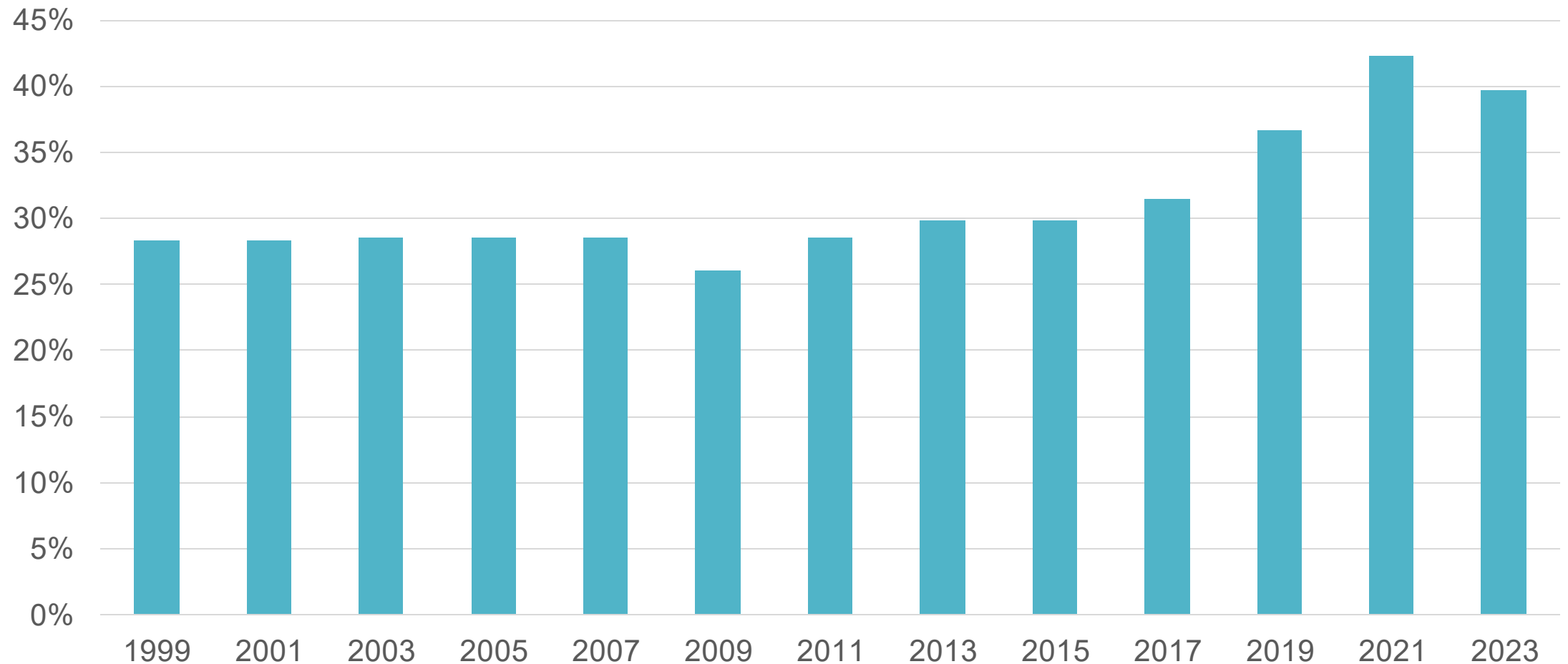


28%
Gen X



24%
Boomers

High school students experienced persistent feelings of sadness or hopelessness



A close-up photograph of a computer keyboard where several keys have been replaced with social media icons. The icons include Facebook (blue 'f'), YouTube (red and white logo), Twitter (blue bird), Instagram (camera), LinkedIn (blue 'in'), and others. The background is a soft, out-of-focus blue gradient.

Social Media's Impact on Loneliness



Not a replacement for in-person encounters.

Leads to and reinforces feeling lonely.

Increased social media use correlated with greater loneliness, even after accounting for age, cohabitation with a partner, employment, and health worry.

Impacts social skills.



Social Media Benefits

Discovering new interest groups

Staying connected with distant friends & family

Limit to 30 mins/day



How Can We Help?

Assessment Tools

University of California Los Angeles Loneliness Scale

The Rasch-Type Loneliness Scale (RTLTS) / De Jong Gierveld

Loneliness Scale (DJGLS)

Loneliness and Aloneness Scale for Children and Adolescents (LACA)

Children Loneliness Scale (CLS)

School Professionals

Social Emotional Learning, SEL

Interactive Learning

Mentoring programs

Social connection in health curriculum

Support of clubs and extracurriculars

School events

Community Professionals

Familiarize yourself with organizations in your community

Intrapersonal: targeting internal characteristics (esteem, negativity, negative emotions)

Interpersonal: behavioral representation of interaction with others (social and communication skills)

Identity exploration/beliefs/values

Guidance on healthy social media engagement

Offer resources and support for parents

Questions/Thoughts?



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Resources

United States. Public Health Service. Office of the Surgeon General. (2023). Our Loneliness and Isolation Epidemic: The U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory on the Healing Effects of Social Connection and Community.

U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Public Health Service, Office of the Surgeon General. Piore, Adam. (2023, December 8). As Teen Loneliness Rates Soar, Schools May Be Making it Worse. Newsweek.

Kaiser Permanente. (2023, December 8). Does social media make you feel lonely? Here's why and how to avoid it.

U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Public Health Service, Office of the Surgeon General. (2023, December 8). Current Priorities for the U.S. Surgeon General

Travers, Mark. (2023, December 8). Are You Suffering from Social-Media-Induced Loneliness? Forbes.

Sebero, Heather. (2023, December 8). Addressing the Youth Mental Health and Loneliness Crisis Through Social Connection in Schools. Association of State and Territorial Health Officials.

Mental Health America. (2023, December 8). Is Your Child Lonely (For Parents).

<https://addhealth.cpc.unc.edu/>

<https://www.thetrevorproject.org>

Hunt MG, Marx R, Lipson C, Young J. No More FOMO: Limiting Social Media Decreases Loneliness and Depression. Journal of Social and Clinical Psychology. 2018;37(10):751-768.

Deaths: Leading Causes for 2021

Youth Risk Survey Results 2023

Suicide and Homicide Death Rates Among Youth and Young Adults Aged 10–24: United States, 2001–2021

Resources

Protecting Youth Mental Health

Emergency Department Visits With Suicidal Ideation: United States, 2016–2020

Addressing Pediatric Suicide

Daily Screen Time Among Teenagers: United States, July 2021–December 2023

<https://mhanational.org/issues/2024/mental-health-america-youth-data>

<https://www.monitoringthefuture.org>

<https://www.pewresearch.org>

Associations between social media use and loneliness in a cross-national population: do motives for social media use matter?